

Lecture 14 - Essay writing

The Social Brain: Critical Perspectives on Science, Society and Neurodiversity

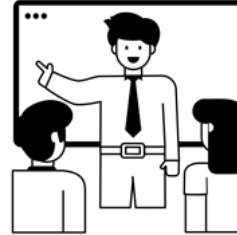
Richard Ramsey



Today

Part 1

- Essay writing



Part 2

- Q&A plus discussion



Summary

- Essay writing:
 - assessment details
 - tips and style guide



Assessment details



Assessment type

- There is one piece of assessment in this course, which is a written assignment in essay format.
- 2000 words maximum.
- Submission date: Monday January 6th, 2026.
- **There is NO exam**
- Just email me the file. If I do not write back to you with confirmation within a few days, then email me again.



Assessment format

You can write your essay in two different ways.

1. Address a general question.

e.g., Is psychology a science or a pseudoscience?

2. Address a more specific question.

e.g., Should Autism be considered one diagnosis or multiple different diagnoses?



Assessment structure

Example structure (it seems obvious, but nonetheless...):

- Introduction
- Main body of the essay
- Conclusion



Assessment content

Things to cover:

- Identify an open research question, which warrants further attention
- Provide a brief background to the topic
- Highlight a gap in knowledge (what we do not know)
- Be critical
- Identify a novel research question or research direction
- State your hypotheses and/or aims
- Discuss the implications of the research (why is it worth doing?)



Assessment criteria

Threshold

- Adequate understanding of the material is demonstrated, which is largely based on information provided within lectures.

Good

- Generally accurate coverage of relevant material, which shows evidence of independent thought that extends lecture materials. Well organised and structured.

Excellent

- Consistently accurate coverage of relevant material, which shows a depth of independent thought that comprehensively extends lecture materials. Well organised and structured with a clear and efficient writing style.



tips and style guide



Narrow focus

- Your essay should have a narrow focus, I do not want a detailed literature review.
- You are not being assessed on the breadth of your knowledge. Therefore, I will not mark you down for having a narrow focus.
- However, I expect a very clear and well-supported rationale for your critical viewpoint and future direction.
- I will reward attempts to think on your own.



Keep it simple !!!

- Find a topic from my lectures that interests you
- Go away and read around the topic
- Think of a feature that limits understanding – i.e., be critical – and suggest a way to extend current knowledge
- It can be as simple as finding one past experiment, highlighting a clear gap in knowledge and explaining how your proposed new approach will add to understanding.



Plan, plan and plan some more

- Plan your written assignment **BEFORE** you start to write. You will find it easier to write if you organise your ideas first into a structure.
- Consider the balance of your assignment, in terms of the amount of text per section.
- Make multiple plans, rather than one. One page A4 per plan.
- Review the plans and consider revision and/or consolidation.



Writing style

- Clarity is crucial.
- Say it in fewer words, if you can (i.e., keep sentences short).
- Link paragraphs together to promote flow.
- ~150 words per paragraph ($2000/150 = \sim 13$ paragraphs).
- It can be shorter (e.g., 1500 words). Max=2000.
- Have a friend or classmate read it.



Read articles and discuss



Discussion material

Discuss essay writing:

- See the resources on the course website:
 - [University of Melbourne link](#)
 - [ETH link](#)
- Do some of your own research on what makes a good essay.
- Consider the structure and content of your essays.
- Class discussion before individual questions.



References

Ellis, S. (12 Aug 2024 10:42am, 12 Aug 2024 10:42am). *Writing a great essay*. Students. <https://students.unimelb.edu.au/academic-skills/resources/reading,-writing-and-referencing/essays/writing-a-great-essay>

Scientific writing. (n.d.). ETH Library. Retrieved August 19, 2025, from <https://library.ethz.ch/en/researching-and-publishing/scientific-writing-at-eth-zurich.html>



Acknowledgements

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